Reimagining Constellation Myths

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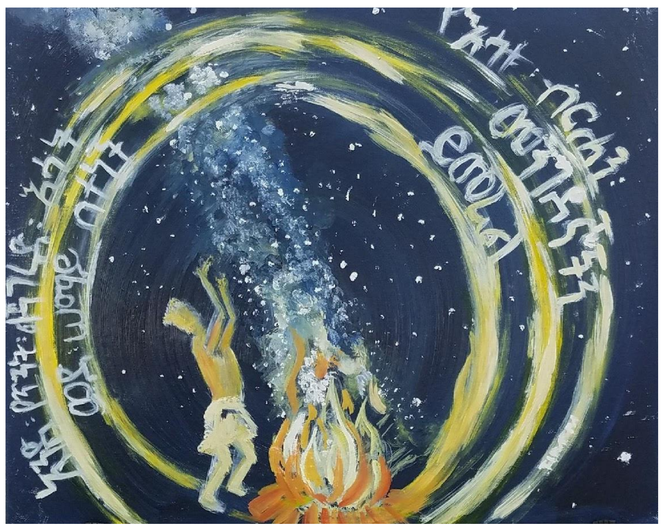
Aethiopian Royals

The two paintings in this diptych have related meaning but can also stand alone. The first painting depicts the human constellations Cassiopeia, Andromeda, and Cepheus, as well as the animal constellations Cetus and Pegasus. In Greek mythology, Cassiopeia and Cepheus are the queen and king of Aethiopia, and Andromeda is their daughter. Cassiopeia claims that she and her daughter are more beautiful than the Nereids, companions of Poseidon. This angers the sea god, who he sends Cetus, a sea monster, to ravage the lands of Aethiopia. The king and queen consult an oracle who tells them to sacrifice Andromeda in order to appease the monster. They chain her to rocks next to the sea to be devoured by Cetus but is saved by Perseus (a Greek hero) at the last moment. Realizing that Cassiopeia's punishment has not been completed, Poseidon confines her to the skies, with an orbit that is upside down for half of the year.
This narration piqued my interest for several reasons, one of which being that the only time black humans is mentioned in constellation mythologies, they are the antagonists. Given that the night sky has been an object of contemplations for people throughout the ancient world, I found it interesting that the dominant narrative we have is one that penalizes a black woman for being beautiful. As a result, I reimagine the myth as only containing the black characters of the story in my painting, with no Perseus to swoop in and save the day. In addition, I abstracted Cetus so that it is not obvious anymore whether the creature is a maleficent beast of destruction, or a tame castle pet.

Milky Way Home



The second painting also depicts a constellation myth, this time of the Khosian hunter-gatherers in Southern Africa. Passed down from generation to generation, it recounts how a girl from ancient times scooped up some fire and threw it into the sky to light the path of travelers as they go home. The writing around the painting is an Amharic retelling of this myth.

"አንድ ፡ የጥንት ፡ ልጃገረድ ፡ እሳት ፡ ወደ ፡ ሰማይ ፡ በተነች። የእሳቱ ፡ ብርሐን ፡ መንገደኞችን " ይመራል።"
"An ancient girl threw fire into the sky, the light of which guides travelers."

I chose to depict this story to show that even though we are usually not taught about them, civilizations throughout the world have their narratives to explain the what they see in the night sky. The fact that the higher education only acknowledges and retells Greek constellations now points to the devastating erasure that colonialism has brought about, not the validity of one story over another. As an international African student, it was important for me to highlight non-Western, black constellation stories because when I look up into the night sky, these are the people I can most easily imagine looking up same as me. Besides, no one owns the sky anyway, so I believe that each myth is story as another.